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Article 4:
VIRTUE ETHICS

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ARTICLE 4: VIRTUE ETHICS

"…Happiness is an activity of soul in accordance with perfect virtue…"[1]

Aristotle Book I, Ch. 13 of the Nicomachean Ethics

Section I: Introduction

The question, *what kind of persons should we be*, seems as fundamental to the moral endeavor as those inquiring into which actions are right/wrong and why. For many people, it is not enough to simply act in accordance with moral rules. One's attitudes towards these rules and other aspects of life matter as well. And, while it is true that both utilitarian and respect for persons (RFP) ethics have assigned some importance to the virtues, neither rivals Aristotelian virtue ethics with regard to its sophisticated approach to moral character. Though this is likely due to the fact that both utilitarians and RFP theorists have treated principles as the foundation of right/wrong, this point remains somewhat ironic given that Aristotle's approach far predates both Kant and Mill's. This sophistication, coupled with the claim that right/wrong should be reckoned in terms of character traits (instead of principles), has made virtue ethics an interesting and increasingly popular approach to contemporary moral problems. At a minimum, this approach promises to yield insightful answers to the question *what kind of persons should we be*.

Keeping with the explanatory strategy of the previous two articles, a specific formulation of virtue ethics will be used to explain some of the fundamental claims and mechanics of the approach. In this article exclusive emphasis will be placed on an Aristotelian[2] approach to virtue ethics. Some of the virtues from Aristotle's own list will be used as well some he did not discuss; the latter being used within his framework. Additionally, this article will explain the relationship between the virtues and happiness (as highlighted in the quote above). This relationship is important inasmuch as it provides the justification for the virtues and provides motivation to lead a virtuous life.

Section II, then, of this paper will examine how Aristotelian virtue ethics would answer the three questions (What is the supreme principle of morality? How should we solve moral problems? What kind of persons should we be?) which were discussed in the context of utilitarianism and RFP ethics – thus completing the comparative overview of these three major moral theories. Section III will discuss two key criticisms of the approach along with two potential responses to these criticisms. Finally, section IV will enumerate some of the lessons to be learned from Aristotle, not the least of which is the importance of focusing on persons and not just actions.

Before moving into Section II, a crucial distinction among virtue accounts must be made. Some virtue accounts are intended to supplement other moral approaches such as utilitarianism or RFP ethics. As was discussed earlier, these accounts assign a secondary status to moral virtues. In other words, the virtues are based upon or derived from foundational principles of morality such as the Principle of Utility or Kant's Categorical Imperative.

That either approach is developing an account of virtue is encouraging inasmuch as it reflects a more complete view of the moral endeavor. Moreover, this supplemental view of virtue ethics is potentially made more attractive by the criticism, to be discussed in Section III, that virtue ethics depends upon foundational principles such as those found in either utilitarianism or RFP ethics.

This criticism notwithstanding, a different approach to virtue ethics will be assumed here. The virtue account described in this paper is intended to be a standalone account; one that does not *require* the insights of the other two approaches for justification. Virtue theory, here, will be treated as a self-sufficient rival to both the utilitarian and RFP approaches to morality.

Section II: *The Questions*

- ***Question 1: What is the supreme principle of morality?***

One might be tempted to begin a virtue ethics approach by listing all of those traits that are to be labeled as virtues and therefore pursued. However, such an approach would quickly lead to legitimate questions

[1] Aristotle, The Nicomachean Ethics, trans. David Ross (Oxford: OUP, 1998), pg. 24

[2] Meaning insights from both Aristotle himself and those seeking to improve his approach (Neo-Aristotelians) will be used.

about why certain traits are considered virtuous while others are not. For example, why is honesty a virtue and not (good) cooking? If one begins with nothing but a list, there is little one can do to respond to such questions besides reiterate the list (perhaps more forcefully the second time around). A better foundation for the approach is needed. As discussed above, one way to establish such a foundation is to look to theories like utilitarianism or RFP ethics. How, by contrast, would a standalone virtue approach proceed?

In his *Nicomachean Ethics,* Aristotle begins with the claim that all human activities are aimed at some end.[3] The end of military engagement is victory, the end of medicine is health and so on. Each end gives purpose and focus to the activity in question. Aristotle reasons that these ends cannot go on *ad infinitum;* there must be an ultimate end that lies at the heart of all human activity which we pursue for its own sake.[4] Why, for example, is good health important? Identifying such a foundational end thus has important implications for human life. It is what all human activity ultimately aims at and it serves as the foundation for the virtue ethics approach being discussed in this paper.

According to Aristotle, the ultimate end for human beings is happiness.[5] However, it is important to recognize that his understanding of happiness differs from the way happiness is typically understood these days. In modern usage, happiness is often viewed as a highly subjective concept. What makes one person happy might not do so for another and one conception of happiness is not necessarily superior to another.

By contrast, Aristotle was referring to an objective good that applied to all people simply in virtue of being human beings. This point can be reinforced by recognizing that the original Greek word for happiness, *eudaimonia*, has also been translated as "flourishing" or "well-being". Both of these latter terms do a better job capturing the objective nature of *eudaimonia*. What is important here is that Aristotle claimed that the ultimate end was one that applied to all human beings and was thus objective in nature (as opposed to being relative to either individuals or a culture). That this end applies to all human beings has significant implications for the virtues.

On the Aristotelian view, the good life (i.e. the one in which one flourishes/is happy) entails the development and exercise of those capacities essential to human beings. In order to be happy, people must be challenged to grow; a life dedicated to the pursuit of sensual pleasure alone is incomplete. For example, being happy requires that one develop one's intellect and power of discernment. Moreover, human happiness requires meaningful relationships; the right kind of friendships for example.[6] Importantly, happiness also requires that one act correctly in a variety of spheres of human conduct.[7]

Two important features emerge from the picture painted thus far. First, this conception of human happiness is wide ranging, covering a variety of aspects of human existence. On a practical level this is important because, as was seen in the utilitarianism article, arguing that human activity reduces to a single good like pleasure fails to capture the complexity of life. Second, virtuous behavior is a *necessary* component of the good life. The view is not that the virtues lead to happiness; that they are instrumental to happiness. Rather, the view is that part of what it means to be happy is to be virtuous. That is, the virtues play a constitutive role in the good life.

This idea, that the good life requires intellectual and moral development, authentic/deep relationships and the like seems intuitively plausible. Consider the following example:

Abe lives in a small basement apartment in his building. A wealthy grandmother left Abe an inheritance sizeable enough for him to live a basic existence without working. He spends the entirety of his days in his apartment, playing video games, eating frozen pizzas and sleeping. It is hard to say that Abe is flourishing as a human being. He is not doing anything to develop his various capacities and talents. He has no friends, does not keep in touch with his family and so forth. At a minimum, his life is incomplete.

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[3] Ibid pg. 1

[4] Ibid pgs 1-2

[5] Ibid pg 5

[6] Ibid pgs. 192-246

[7] This is a very brief treatment of the components of a good life. It should be treated as neither exhaustive nor definitive.

The robust, multi-faceted conception of happiness discussed so far is able to explain why his life is incomplete; to account for this intuition.

Notice the similarities here between the virtue ethics approach and utilitarianism. Both begin with *the good* which is foundational and worth pursuing for its own sake, and derive a standard of right/wrong from this good.

However, the virtue approach departs from both utilitarianism and the RFP approach in that it does not start with a supreme principle focused on the moral status of actions (e.g. asking if an action promote the greatest good for the greatest number or treat people as ends-in-themselves). Rather, Aristotelian virtue ethics begins with a foundational claim about human happiness; holding that the virtues are a part of and necessary to happiness.

From this claim, a method and list of virtues can be identified which can be in turn applied to practical moral problems.

- ***Question 2 – How should we solve moral problems?***

Here again, it might be tempting to answer this question by enumerating the virtues and examining how they apply to particular moral problems. However, doing this would shed no insight into what a virtue is or on the complexity associated with virtuous action and living. Thus, it is important to begin with an account of what a virtue is and what it means to act virtuously.

Simply stated, a virtue is a character trait or a disposition regarding a specific sphere of human conduct (e.g. honesty, courage, temperance, etc.). A person possesses the virtue of honesty, for example, if he consistently performs honest acts (e.g. does not lie, goes out of his way to tell the "whole truth", etc.). But, virtue requires that one do more than consistently perform a given type of action (e.g. honest actions).

Being virtuous, according to Aristotle, is in part a matter of choosing the mean between two extremes; excess and deficiency.[8] For example, courage is the mean between foolhardiness (excess) and cowardice (deficiency). Temperance (regarding various forms of pleasure) is the mean between licentiousness (excess) and what he called insensitivity (deficiency). This is Aristotle's "Doctrine of the Golden Mean".[9]

However, it is not enough to choose the mean between two extremes on one or a few occasions. One (or a few) virtuous action does not a virtuous person make.[10] Consider Joan: if Joan is a benevolent person, it is not because she acted benevolently towards someone on one or a few occasions. Rather, she is benevolent because she *consistently* acts benevolently. A virtue, then, is a character trait, the full development of which requires not only thoughtfulness but also practice.

The idea that the virtues are the result of habit leads to the view that the moral endeavor is active in nature.[11] That is, one cannot simply think benevolent thoughts and thereby become benevolent. Rather, benevolence requires action on the part of the person aspiring to be virtuous. This active element of virtue ethics is one of its strengths inasmuch as it requires the virtue aspirant to directly engage the world as opposed to simply thinking about good things. Stated differently, ethical behavior is a function of what a person *does* in the world and is not a matter of refraining from committing certain impermissible acts.

Furthermore, virtue requires not only that one consistently act in a certain way, but that one do so with the right attitude toward the action.

Thinking back to Joan, suppose that in the beginning of her volunteer work, when she first identified benevolence as a worthy trait, she did not derive much pleasure from her work or otherwise have much inclination to do it. Nevertheless, she persevered from a desire to become a benevolent person.

Over time, Joan's attitude towards her volunteer work changed such that she looked forward to her time at the shelter and, in fact, derived pleasure from the work. In the beginning, she was, according to Aristotle,

[8] Ibid pg. 31

[9] Aristotle did not believe that one should aim for the mean in all activities/actions. There is not a right amount of murder, rape, or theft.

[10] Ibid pg. 14

[11] Ibid pg. 28

merely exercising self-control or discipline over her inclination against volunteer work. While praiseworthy, this self-control (what he referred to as "continence"[12]) is not a virtue. Joan's actions only become virtuous when she fully internalizes the reasons to be benevolent. The virtuous person will derive satisfaction or pleasure from her virtue.[13]

While some have debated the necessity of this last criterion to the evaluation of moral behavior, at a minimum Aristotle has captured another important intuition here. Namely, that those people who act from a genuine interest and motivation in virtuous (or right) action, should be held in higher esteem than those who must struggle against their own ignoble inclinations (e.g. acting benevolently in the presence of an inclination towards extreme selfishness) while performing the same action.

This view, that virtuous actions are those performed from an internal desire to do them (are done with a sense of satisfaction or pleasure) also has another advantage. If, in the pursuit of virtue, one develops an inclination to be benevolent, honest, courageous, etc, one is more likely to follow through on this inclination and perform the morally correct action. Contrast this with someone who is always at war with himself about doing the right thing -eventually this person will likely experience a weakness of will and fail to do what he ought to.

- ***Question 3 – What kind of persons should we be?***

Having established how the virtues relate to the ultimate end of human activity and discussed what a virtue is (in part), it is now appropriate to consider some specific virtues. For the purposes of this paper, moral virtues will be divided into two broad categories, those that apply to all human beings and those that apply to individuals in virtue of their specific social roles (e.g. physicians, engineers, lawyers, etc.). This latter category will be referred to as *role virtue*.

Moral Virtues

Aristotle's list of virtues includes courage, temperance, liberality[14], the virtue of right anger, and pride. This list does not need to be treated as exhaustive, but it represents a good start and demonstrates the wide scope of dispositions that a virtue ethics approach is concerned with. It might be tempting to think of the virtues as being concerned with spheres with obvious moral content – justice or benevolence for example. Instead, what emerges here is a more holistic conception of what it means to be a good human being.

Some critics have argued that the virtue ethics approach is excessively focused on the self and thereby deficient in its concern for other people. With respect to temperance, one is concerned with having the right attitude towards pleasure, with courage the right attitude towards danger, with liberality the right attitude towards money and so forth. In each case, the focus is on the cultivation of *one's own disposition* in a particular sphere of life. The criticism seems reinforced by the explanation of how the virtues are related to happiness. One ought to be virtuous because doing so is part of what it means to be a happy human being. Here the motivation appears to be overtly selfish. One is performing virtuous actions *because* doing so is part of the happy life.

However, this criticism is ill-founded. In acting intemperately one harms not only oneself, but often times others as well. Clearly a person's vicious (excess) attitude with respect to alcohol impacts not only himself, but those around him (e.g. friends, family, victims of DUI, etc.). Aristotle was concerned with not only how a vicious attitude impacted one's own pursuit of happiness, but how the same impacted other people's pursuit of happiness. The virtuous person is not simply one who pursues her own self development to the exclusion of all else; the virtuous person also cares about others. Moreover, the virtuous person cares about other people *for their own sake* and not simply because caring about other people somehow contributes to his happiness.

Aristotle's list of virtues does not have to be treated as an exhaustive one. It can be relatively easily to adapt additional virtues to the mechanics of the Aristotelian approach as it has been described so far.

[12] Ibid pgs 159-191

[13] Ibid pgs 31-33

[14] Aristotle's word for the virtue dealing with money (and not a political stance).

Aristotle's own list included not only moral virtues, but intellectual ones as well.[15] This additional category makes for interesting applications to the practice of engineering specifically.

Role Virtue

On the virtue ethics view, engineers ought to be temperate, courageous, liberal, benevolent etc. like everyone else.[16] However, engineers also need to cultivate virtues specific to their work as engineers. Engineers need to demonstrate technical competence in their work. A civil engineer, for example, needs to account for a variety of environmental factors when designing a structure. Engineers must also demonstrate an appropriate level of discernment. They should be able to distinguish between recognized design standards and optional design styles. Engineers must also demonstrate professional autonomy at the appropriate times. They must know when it is permissible to defer to the decisions made by management and when doing so would be inappropriate (e.g. when a decision will potentially negatively impact the public). Thus, one can argue that, in addition to being temperate, courageous, liberal and benevolent, engineers must cultivate the engineering specific virtues of technical competence, discernment, and professional autonomy.[17,18] The same mechanics of the virtue approach discussed above could be applied here as well. Virtuous competence, for example, will be the mean between being excessively theoretical and incompetent. These virtues, in a vain similar to the happiness argument, are part of what it means to be a good engineer. This call to be the right kind of engineer is already reflected in many of the major engineering codes of ethics.

Practical Wisdom

Finally, anyone interested in being virtuous must not only demonstrate an established tendency to perform certain actions with the correct attitude, one must also perform the right action, at the right time, towards the right people, for the right duration and with the right intensity. For example, return to the virtue of benevolence. One must know what to do, know who to help, how much assistance to give, when to give it, for how long, and do so for the right reasons. Helping someone out too much for too long might actually hurt the beneficiary of the action (in the big picture). Achieving this delicate balance requires what Aristotle referred to as *practical wisdom*.[19]

Acting virtuously requires practice and sensitivity to situation specific details. What is the correct duration of assistance in one situation might not be so in another (or with respect to another person). The practically wise person will understand what benevolence, for instance, demands in each scenario. Though this last piece adds complexity to the virtue approach, it is a complexity that is already in the world and not merely a byproduct of the theory.

Sometimes decision-makers are condemned for having intentions or performing an action that would otherwise be appropriate under another set of circumstances. They are condemned because their actions failed to account for the relevant details of the situation; they failed to demonstrate practical wisdom.[20] This ability to account for a complex phenomenon counts as a strength of the virtue approach.

Section III: Criticisms and Responses

[15] See Book VI of the *Nicomachean Ethics*.

[16] Doubtless these virtues will have specific applications in engineering. An engineer's intemperance with respect to alcohol can certainly threaten the quality of his work, for instance.

[17] One could easily argue that each of these virtues ought to be demonstrated by other professionals such as physicians and lawyers. This is true, though how the virtues are defined (e.g. what counts as technical competence) will obviously remain discipline specific.

[18] Doubtless, there are other engineering specific virtues in addition to technical competence, discernment, and professional autonomy.

[19] Ibid pgs. 142-143

[20] Using an example from a recent lecture, the compassion we show a known serial killer will and should be different than the compassion we show an ailing family member (or even an innocent stranger).

In this section two challenges to virtue theory will be considered. The first challenge deals with the possibility of an objective good, one that does not vary with individuals or cultures, for human beings. Much rides on the plausibility of the account of human happiness sketched thus far. The second challenge deals with the sufficiency of virtue ethics as a standalone account. As with the previous articles, responses to both of these criticisms will also be briefly explored.

Happiness and Subjectivity

Recall that Aristotle's conception of happiness is one that is fairly different from the modern day conception. Happiness in the latter context is highly subjective. Typically, a person is judged to be happy if that person is satisfied with his/her life. Moreover, different people hold different conceptions of a happy life. A happy life for person A might be one dedicated to the pursuit of pleasure whereas person B's idea of a happy life involves academic distinction. This conception, in short, is a subjective one. By contrast, Aristotle and other ancient philosophers held that happiness (*eudaimonia*) is an objective standard, one that is relativized not to individuals or to a culture, but to all human beings. Happiness, "the good", is objective and is based upon the innate and essential characteristics of human beings.

Though initially plausible and appealing, the idea that there is an objective good for human beings has met with considerable criticism amongst philosophers. Understanding what, if any, objective good there is for people has proven to be a difficult project. And this difficulty is not merely an academic one. Thoughtful, practicing engineers interested in following the engineering codes of ethics encounter similar problems when trying to understand what upholding the *welfare of the public* really amounts to. The codes, of course, do nothing to fill in what welfare means.[21]

Up until this point in the article, the terms "happiness", "flourishing", and "well-being" have been treated as being roughly synonymous. However, the terms "well-being" and "welfare", more specifically, will be used in discussing philosopher L.W. Sumner's approach. That being said, the discussion will still be aimed at the Aristotelian conception of happiness laid out in this article so far.

A person cannot be judged well-off, according to Sumner, without reference to that person's attitude towards his/her situation; a plausible theory of welfare must include this subjective component.[22] Objective theories of welfare, like Aristotle's, fail to account for this essential subjective component.[23] To talk of someone as being well off, independent of that person's particular view of his life, is mistaken according to Sumner. An example will help make this criticism clearer and more forceful.

Suppose that James appears to be living the good life. He is temperate when the situation calls for it, courageous when courage is called for, etc. Furthermore, suppose that he has the requisite amount of material wealth and relationships to make his life complete. Nevertheless, James does not feel well-off or happy with his life; perhaps due to a gnawing existential crisis. For the moment the cause of his dissatisfaction is not important. What is important is that he himself is not satisfied with his life.

If the objective account is correct and he, as has been laid out, has all the necessary pieces (virtue, the right relationships, and material conditions), it seems that it must be said that he is well-off. But, can one be well-off and not know it (or even deny such well-being)?

At a minimum, this seems like an odd implication of the view. More forcefully, this kind of example might lead to the conclusion that an objective account of welfare is missing a critical component, the one Sumner points out, the attitude of the person experiencing the state of affairs.[24] If welfare is truly only an objective concept, one that is independent of a decision-maker's own feelings about the matter, then, initially, it is not clear how to avoid this counterintuitive implication.

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[21] This should not be automatically viewed as a deficiency in the codes. There are, arguably, good reasons to leave the codes somewhat vague in nature.

[22] Sumner, L.W. Welfare, Happiness, and Ethics (Oxford University Press, 1996),

pgs. 42-43

[23] Ibid pg. 43

[24] Note: Sumner's position is not that objective theories are simply missing a component. He argues for the subjectivity of welfare (not the mere incompleteness of objective approaches).

One way to respond to Sumner here is to deny that Aristotle's account overlooks this subjective aspect of welfare. This is what Christopher Toner has in mind in his article "Aristotelian Well-Being: A Response to L.W. Sumner's Critique".[25] Toner draws attention to an aspect of Aristotle's theory discussed in Section II, Question 2 above – Aristotle argued that virtue demands not only that one perform the right action, at the right intensity, for the right duration, etc. but also that one have the right attitude towards the right action. Recall that Aristotle argued that the virtuous person will derive pleasure from virtuous activity.[26] Absent this pleasure, an action is not yet virtuous (even if, again, it reflects self-control). For Toner, this satisfaction with virtuous activity (along with finding one's friends, family, and level of material prosperity pleasurable) addresses the subjective dimension of welfare. He states:

> *To be well-off on Sumner's account an agent[27] must be satisfied with his life, cognitively and affectively…It seems fairly clear that Aristotle's spoudaios, the mature and flourishing man, will meet these requirements. Cognitively he will affirm his life, for he will see it as the best life available to him. Affectively he will be satisfied, for he will be active and enjoying his activities, his friends, and possessions.[28]*

So, returning to the example, while James appears, from the outside, to be well-off he is, in fact, not because he lacks the appropriate attitude towards his actions and life.

It is worth pointing out that this debate about the nature of welfare has implications beyond virtue ethics. If welfare is entirely an objective concept, one that, as Sumner maintains, makes no reference to the subjective dimension discussed heretofore, it is entirely plausible that one individual can act in what appears to be another person's well-being with no reference to the recipient's feelings on the matter.

Suppose an engineer named Vincent decides that what a local community needs is a dam to significantly improve the community's safety and access to an important source of water.[29] But, suppose that this dam will cause the flooding of upstream areas which are viewed by the people of the community as having great cultural significance. For this reason, local community members are against the project. Nevertheless, Vincent reasons that the dam really will, in the big picture, promote the well-being of the people and thus fiercely argues for its construction.

This action on Vincent's part might be condemned by some, in part, because it is excessively paternalistic. Whether or not paternalism is ever justified is a debate distinct from this one. But, another reason Vincent's actions might be condemned is because his judgment about the happiness or well-being of the people was made irrespective of the feelings of those who would be impacted by the dam.

The worry here is that one should not talk about what is good for people without consulting the people themselves or otherwise taking into account their view of happiness/well-being.

This has proven to be a difficult and frequently occurring problem in the practice of engineering.

The Self-Sufficiency of Standalone Virtue Accounts

A major test for any moral theory is whether or not it is complete; can it justify its basic claims without depending upon the insights of another moral theory? Virtue ethics has been criticized for failing this test. Specifically, William Frankena claimed that virtue ethics was essentially incomplete. According to Frankena, virtue ethics, by itself, is unable to explain which traits are virtues to begin with.[30] Why, for example, are temperance and courage virtues but not cooking or golf playing? How does an appeal to human happiness justify honesty as a virtue without itself presupposing a moral standard? That is, how does one know that honesty is a virtue if not because of the principle that it is wrong to deceive people?

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[25] Toner, Christopher Hugh "Aristotelian Well-Being: A Response to L.W. Sumner's Critique" *Utilitas* vol. 18, no. 3 (Sept. 2006), pgs. 218-231.

[26] Aristotle, pgs. 31-33

[27] In these articles the term "decision-maker" has been used as a stand-in for "agent".

[28] Toner, pg. 227

[29] The general benefits of dam building are assumed to be familiar enough to the reader that enumerating them is not necessary here.

[30] Frankena, William K Ethics 2nd ed. (Upper Saddle River: Prentice-Hall, 1973)
pgs. 65-66

On this view, the realization that honesty is a virtue is possible only because there exists a more basic principle that condemns deception. A virtue account thus relies upon basic moral principles, ones that utilitarianism or RFP ethics are concerned with identifying. A standalone virtue account is incapable of justifying such principles. According to Frankena, this does not mean that virtue ethics is without value in the moral endeavor. He maintained that cultivating the right dispositions remained an important activity.[31] Nevertheless, his hybrid account still assigned primary status to moral principles.

One way to respond to Frankena is to appeal to scientific facts about human beings to motivate, in part, which character traits ought to be cultivated. For example, human beings are social creatures and human interactions are not based solely on self-interested transactions. That is, it is characteristic of human beings that they sometimes act benevolently towards other humans and do so for altruistic reasons. Part of what it is to be the right kind of human being, then, is to be benevolent (to act benevolently for the right reason at the right time, for the right duration etc.).[32]

In theory, the case for benevolence and other virtues can be made without appealing to preexisting principles of right and wrong. Instead, the case for the virtues can be made by appealing to facts and features of human existence. This view is one form of ethical naturalism and, if successful, can justify a standalone view of virtue ethics.

Here again, the practical implications of this debate are significant. If in fact critics of standalone accounts are correct, then moral right and wrong will be reckoned in terms of principles like those offered by utilitarianism (Principle of Utility) or RFP ethics (e.g. Kant's Categorical Imperative). This means, for example, that when evaluating the permissibility of a course of action in a particular scenario, the fundamental question to be answered is whether or not, given utilitarianism, the course of action will maximize the good.

Character traits come into the equation only insofar as these help promote and/or ensure the right course of action or inasmuch as there is an interest in evaluating the praiseworthiness (vs. rightness) of a decision-maker's disposition(s). Assuming a standalone approach to virtue ethics, by contrast, will mean that the rightness of the same course of action will be reckoned in terms of the relevant character traits. Thus, the outcome of this debate does critically impact how practical moral problems are approached.

Section IV: Take-Home Lessons

There are at least several lessons that can be learned from the Aristotelian approach to virtue ethics. First, the virtue approach captures the idea that the rightness/wrongness of a situation depends not only on the evaluation of the actions involved, but on the attitude of those performing the action. A morally permissible action performed with ignoble motivations seems to not only fail to be praiseworthy, but fails to be right. If intuitions are accurate here, virtue ethics can straightforwardly account for this observation.

Second, the virtue approach also reflects the idea that ethical behavior in the real world demands situational sensitivity. It can be argued that blanket, abstract pronouncements about what is right and wrong fail to account for relevant situation specific details. Like the act utilitarian, the virtue inclined person is able to take these into account when deciding what a given virtue demands in a given situation.

Both act-utilitarianism and virtue ethics allow for a level of flexibility that seems appropriate to the moral endeavor while not giving up the notion of an objective standard for right and wrong. Furthermore, among other considerations, the virtuous person will consider the consequences of an action when determining what the virtuous course of action is in a given situation. Thus, this approach reinforces the utilitarian claim[33] that consequences do have a role to play in moral evaluation.

The virtue approach is able to move well beyond the notion that morality is simply the enumeration of obligatory acts or rules. Instead, decision-makers are asked to consider their actions in the wider context of what it means to be a good human being. And while the virtue approach does weigh in on traditional

[31] Ibid

[32] This strategy comes from Rosalind Hursthouse. See:

Hursthouse, Rosalind On Virtue Ethics (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), pgs. 192-238.

[33] And the position of those RFP approaches that have abandoned Kant's hard line stance on consequences.

topics in ethics (i.e. what is justice, wrongful killing, benevolence, etc), it also addresses spheres not always common to contemporary conversations (e.g. temperance, right anger, pride, etc.).[34] That is, virtue approaches tend to be more holistic than their utilitarian or RFP cousins.

Finally, virtue ethics points out that certain social roles require character traits over and above those required of all human beings.

Physicians must demonstrate certain traits (competency, compassionate bedside manner, patience, active listening, etc.) to be good physicians.

We unconsciously imitate what pleases us, and approximate to the characters we most admire.

Christian Nestell Bovee
1820-1904

[34] These latter two virtues also come from Aristotle. See the *Nicomachean Ethics* pgs. 89-98.

Tests for Evaluating Actions

(Suggested by Michael Davis, Carl Skooglund, Jimmy Smith & Patricia Harper)

Actions can also be evaluated using the following tests:

Harms Test		Do the benefits outweigh the harms, short term and long term?
Reversibility Test		Would I think this was a good choice if I traded places?
Colleague Test		What would my professional colleagues say?
Legality Test		Would my choice violate a law or policy of my employer?
Publicity Test		How would my choice look on the front page of tomorrow's newspaper?
Common Practice Test		What if everyone behaved this way?
Wise Relative Test		What would my wise old aunt or uncle do? and/or Would I want them to know what I'm doing?
The Hiding Test		Do I want people to know what I'm doing?
The Self-Respect Test		How will I feel about myself after making this choice?

Something to Consider: These tests promote decisions based on how we would "feel" about what we do, or if someone would know, of if we would be caught.

However, the best decision is to "**Do the right thing <u>because</u> it's the right thing to do"** rather than out of fear of consequences.